Challenges in public transport labour: understanding and improving bus drivers' working conditions

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Working conditions and labour supply: challenges to the sustainability of public transport

Public transport (PT) is pivotal for sustainable development, ensuring accessibility in urban and rural areas while reducing CO_2 emissions and contributing to sustainable cities (SDG 11). Its functioning, and the functioning of our societies more broadly, relies on the everyday work of PT workers. Despite this central role, PT work across Europe, including the Nordic region, faces a crisis pertaining to working conditions and labour supply (UITP 2024; IRU 2024).

In Sweden, trade unions and workers report poor working conditions, citing long and stressful working days and inadequate time and spaces for resting (see e.g. local news reports by Gunnarsson 2021; Malmberg 2021). At the same time, PT operators face acute staff shortages (primarily drivers, but also mechanics, traffic controllers, and technicians), leading to frequent service disruptions (Svensk kollektivtrafik 2023). Operators estimate a need for 8,100 new bus drivers before 2026 to guarantee adequate service levels (Transportföretagen 2023). A comparable scenario can be observed in other Nordic countries, such as Denmark (ETF 2022; Vejtransportrådet 2024) and Norway (AFI 2023).

This shortage is expected to worsen due to a forthcoming wave of retirements, driven by the high average age of bus drivers: in 2023, 62% of tram and bus drivers in Sweden were over 50, and only 3% under 30 (Sveriges Bussföretag, 2025). Despite efforts to attract women, the sector remains highly male-dominated (88% of drivers in 2023), and women's participation declined by 10% between 2016 and 2023 (ibid.). Research highlights barriers for women, including atypical hours and lack of safe transport options (ITF/UITP 2019). Recruitment and retention of women and younger drivers remain major concerns.

Understanding bus drivers' working conditions – and how these intersect with gender, age, and other inequalities shaping experiences and coping strategies – is a priority for transport and mobility research. This knowledge is essential for enhancing workers' well-being, making the profession more attractive, and ensuring the sustainability of PT.

Previous and current research about bus drivers in Sweden

Recent studies (Vitrano & Kębłowski, 2024; Winter et al. 2025; Stjernborg & Levin, 2025) have examined the link between bus drivers' working conditions and public transport (PT)

governance, a topic rarely explored in Sweden and, more broadly, in the Global North (notable exceptions include Scholten et al. 2017 and McIntyre 2005). Vitrano & Kębłowski (2024) interviewed Swedish bus drivers, revealing growing time pressure and challenges in maintaining work-life balance, largely due to tight schedules designed for efficiency and punctuality. A qualitative study in southern Sweden (Winter et al., 2025) confirms significant stress, fatigue, and health issues caused by long shifts, minimal recovery time, and limited access to toilets. Despite these challenges, drivers value autonomy, meaningful work, and collegiality but strongly advocate for shorter workdays, better pay, longer breaks, and greater influence over scheduling. Stjernborg and Levin (2025) explored how stakeholders (including PT authorities, national agencies, and trade unions) reflect on the relation between bus drivers' working conditions and accessibility for passengers with disabilities. Financially constrained contracts and procurement practices increase workload and stress, negatively influencing driver behaviour and exacerbating accessibility barriers (ibid.). These studies highlight how procurement models and digitalised rostering systems, aimed at maximising operational performance and rooted in efficiency-driven governance, create unintended consequences for drivers' health and service equity. Relatedly, improving drivers' well-being and ensuring sustainable PT require continuous collaboration among PT authorities, operators, trade unions, and municipalities.

The focus on operational and financial efficiency, engineering and technological performance, as well as current procurement practices and digitalisation seem to have all affected PT working conditions. However, their connection to inequalities among workers—related to gender, class, race/ethnicity, and age—and their historical development remains underexplored. The ongoing project BUSSA1 (2024–2027, funded by FORTE) addresses this gap by analysing challenges to decent working conditions for bus drivers in Sweden and exploring strategies to improve them. The following sections outline some key research questions guiding our work.

How do bus drivers in Sweden experience their working conditions?

In spring 2025, we conducted a survey of bus drivers in Sweden's PT sector, collecting 849 valid responses. The survey examined working time, work intensity, work-life balance, organisation, agency, and demographic factors (e.g., gender, age, education, ethnicity). Preliminary findings show that while 70% enjoy their work, 58% report frequent stress. Notably, 74% believe working conditions have worsened since they started, and 54% would like to leave the profession, underscoring the industry's recruitment and retention challenges. Further analysis will explore intersectional differences and highlight challenges faced by different groups of workers.

Have working conditions always been poor, or are they deteriorating further?

The historical analysis conducted so far in the project shows that demanding working conditions for bus drivers are not new. Organizational goals of effectiveness and

rationalization have shaped PT and resulted in a "race for seconds" in bus drivers' everyday work since at least the mid-1960s. Drivers' voices from the 1960s and 1970s describe substantial time pressure, problems balancing work with family and leisure, and lack of agency (Aronsson et al., 1979). Agency appears to improve in some respects in the early 1980s following the Employment (Co-Determination in the Workplace) Act (1976:580), but organizational changes within PT (such as regionalization and procurement) meant that drivers continued to experience poor working conditions as the sector entered the 1990s. Further research will clarify what characterises the deterioration in working conditions reported by workers today and how it connects to long-standing structural dynamics in the sector.

Are working conditions reflecting inequality regimes?

In BUSSA, we address this question by applying Acker's (2006) concept of "inequality regimes" to analyse how intersecting inequalities – such as gender, race, class, and age – may be embedded, reinforced, manifested and challenged in the organisation of PT work. We adopt a qualitative approach that examine both the actual practices of bus driving and the meaning-making through which workers understand their working conditions. Through mobile ethnography (Novoa, 2015), including ride-alongs with bus drivers, and in-depth interviews with both drivers and other professionals, we aim to examine how spatiotemporal and organisational conditions (such as duty schedules, timetables, and operational routines) shape everyday work practices and the power relations surrounding them, including those linked to gender, race, and class.

Improving working conditions for PT workers: a crucial question for the Nordic countries

Improving working conditions for bus drivers (and PT workers more broadly) is an urgent challenge, which gains even heightened relevance within the framework of the Nordic welfare state. In Nordic countries, PT is recognized as the backbone of a fully sustainable mobility system – environmentally, economically, and socially. A truly sustainable PT system must not only reduce emissions and enhance accessibility but also ensure fair working conditions for those who operate it.

The PT sector, already challenged by demanding working conditions, where goals of efficiency and rationalisation have long dictated everyday operations, has, in recent decades, also been shaped by a growing market orientation of its services. This development raises important questions in the Nordic context, where welfare principles and labour rights are traditionally strong. The evolving landscape highlights tensions between cost-efficiency objectives on the one hand, and commitments to social justice and decent working conditions on the other, highlighting the need for further research to support informed decision-making.

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